

and future warships of the navy. While the bribery case has clearly not impacted the Barak-NG missile, fresh supplies of the Barak hinge on the outcome of the case.

The CBI case is essentially that Fernandes as defence minister overruled the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) which favoured developing the indigenous Trishul missile and got the proposal approved by the Cabinet Committee on Security despite objections from the then defence secretary. Jaitly received a Rs 2-crore kickback from Barak middlemen Suresh and Chowdhury while Admiral Kumar put up a note directly to Fernandes to import six Barak systems, misrepresent-

ble of defending its warships from missile attack—during the Kargil deployment of 1999. Then navy chief Admiral Bhagwat had proposed the acquisition of a single system for the aircraft carrier *Viraat*. Fernandes said he first consulted A.P.J. Abdul Kalam, the then scientific adviser to the prime minister, who agreed to the purchase.

A smaller, lesser-mourned casualty of the bribery scandal will be Suresh's career as a high-profile arms agent. A graduate of the National Defence Academy's 16th course, he quit the navy while serving as his father Admiral S.M. Nanda's flag lieutenant because according to his associates, "his father's looming personality ensured he never got

arms trade of the '80s and '90s gave the Nandas all the trappings of plutocracy: a sprawling mansion on Grosvenor Square in London's exclusive Mayfair district, a mansion on Prithviraj Road in the heart of Lutyen's Delhi and Bentleys and BMWs in the garage. Yet, it did not buy them immunity.

The unravelling began with the Tehelka tapes of 2001 where Jain named Suresh and Chowdhury as recipients of kickbacks in the Barak deal. A case was registered by CBI which followed it up in 2006 with raids on Nandas' premises across the country.

In recent years, the arms dealer had been trying to distance himself from the murky trade and go legit. CBI

CBI IN ITS FIR ON THE DEAL SAYS...

PANKAJ NANGIA



FERNANDES: Cleared the Barak purchase.

HEMANT CHAWLA



R.K. JAIN: Received bribes from middlemen.

PANKAJ NANGIA



JAYA JAITLEY: Received Rs 2 crore as kickback.



ADM SUSHIL KUMAR: Overruled DRDO.

"We have had 13 firings of Barak. We're very happy with it."

ADMIRAL SURESH MEHTA, CHIEF OF THE NAVAL STAFF

ing facts and citing DRDO's concurrence that was given three years earlier when the indigenous Trishul was still at the development stage, despite the DRDO chief opposing the proposal. R.K. Jain, the Samata Party's national treasurer, was given several lakhs of rupees as bribe for pushing Barak through. The final deal of \$268.63 million (Rs 1,125 crore) was inflated by \$17 million (Rs 71 crore).

In reality, it is a brief full of holes. The fact is that as of 1999, the Trishul (a missile which the DRDO has since shelved) was nowhere near induction. The navy went in for the Barak because it was the only anti-missile capa-

credit for anything he did".

Suresh left the service quietly, when Admiral Nanda was travelling overseas because his father had frowned on his move to quit. He then went into business. Sometime in the late 1970s, he was back with his father's firm Crown Corporation. Admiral Nanda who oversaw the navy's finest hour during the 1971 Indo-Pak war, set up the firm ostensibly after his retirement to re-employ retired naval personnel. It quickly became a firm associated with major defence deals concluded with the Soviet Union and later Russia, but there was never any evidence. The booming

alleges the Rs 400-crore in kickbacks re-entered the country to pay for Nandas' big-ticket purchases—the sea facing Sea Rock Hotel in Mumbai's Tony Bandstand and the Claridges on Delhi's Aurangzeb Road. Meanwhile, his father, the 92-year-old 'Man Who Bombed Karachi', as his 2005 autobiography was called, and later inexplicably turned into one of India's biggest arms agents, is now medicated six times a day. His frail six-foot frame is wracked by Parkinson's and he spends most of his time in his Prithviraj Road mansion watching news channels. But none bring his family any good news. ■